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EPILOGUE

Homily at the Funeral of Bernard Lonergan*



Dear friends, my brothers and sisters in the family of God.

With this holy eucharist, and with these ceremonies, we take our leave of one who was with us throughout a long life, and was related to us in many ways. To some he was an older brother, an uncle or cousin. To others a fellow-religious in the family of Ignatius. To still others, a teacher among his students, or a colleague in the world of academe and in the Christian intellectual apostolate. In each of these capacities, and in the diverse ways they suggest, he was very dear to us.

With all of us, with all God's people, he was present in another way that lies at a deeper level: as one of the great human family, with its joys and its hopes, its griefs and its anxieties; as one who came forth, as we all did, from the hand of God, whose life on earth, as for each of us, was a pilgrimage; as one to whom the word has now come, as come it will to us all, that his pilgrimage is over, his days on earth completed, his time fulfilled, his life arrived at its term.

To speak in this way is to suppose that life has a unity. It is to suppose a plan, an ordered course, not just the aimless wandering between a chance beginning and a meaningless end. And so we ask, naturally and with human affection, as relatives and friends, but reverently too, as before God and the mystery of human life, we ask what made the unity in the life of Fr. Bernard Lonergan. We know that three times at least in his life he was very near to death, only to be saved, from a human viewpoint, by major surgery, but from a higher viewpoint, surely by the will of a mysterious providence. And so we wonder about that mysterious providence. Why did not God say, sixty-five or twenty or even two years ago: This life has reached its term? Why only now did God see it as whole and complete?

There is, of course, the familiar metaphor of the course of the day: the morning, noon and evening of life, as forming a natural unity.

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Personally I find a great appeal in that metaphor as applied to the life of Bernard Lonergan. I think of the morning of his life in the valley of the Lièvre. I remember Lampman's poem about morning on that river

Like a vapor from the forge
Of a giant somewhere hid,
Out of hearing of the clang
Of his hammer, skirts of mist
Slowly up the woody gorge
Lift and hang.

And I picture the boy Bernard, as his eyes dwell on those morning mists, and his young mind opens already to receive the wonder of the world. I think of the noontide of his life, when he was at the height of his power in Italy. I remember his own words on the work of Aquinas, that it "shines as unmistakably as the sun on the noonday summer hills of Italy."¹ And I think of his own magnificent intelligence, shedding new light during those years on old questions, uttering wisdom with the clarity of the Italian skies. I think finally of the evening of his life, spent at Regis College and Boston College, when his great masterpieces were done. And again I find a fitting description of this in his own lines on "the serenity of old age, when perforce the self becomes selfless as the field of enjoyment contracts to joy in the enjoyment of others, in the romping vitality of grandchildren."² His grandchildren, to be sure, were his students rather than flesh and blood descendants, and some of us are rather greyhaired to be grandchildren; but it is true that in his declining years he could rest more quietly, knowing that his work was going forward, carried on with boundless energy by a numerous spiritual progeny.

It is a pleasing picture, especially for one who has lived out his allotted fourscore years. And yet I know that it is too idyllic—too idyllic by far for a life that did not in fact run smoothly from morning mists through noonday sun to the shadows of evening. And what alone is important, such a life does not bear much resemblance to the life of him who is our way and our truth, of him whose way and truth Bernard strove throughout life to understand, so that, in the Ignatian prayer, he might love him more and follow him better.

Is it not then to that very source itself, to him who is our way and our truth, that we should turn for enlightenment on our question? He who was sent into the world to be our leader, who invited us to follow him and become his disciples, he seemed to provide, in his great prayer at the last supper, the perfect summation of what a human life on earth

1. *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, p. 219.

2. *Collection: Papers by Bernard Lonergan, S.J.*, p. 37.

should be: "I have glorified thee on earth by completing the work which thou gavest me to do" (Jn 17:4). Have we here the clue we seek to the unity of life, of life for anyone? Is it not to be found in completing the work that God has given each of us to do? And must we not study the work that Bernard was given to do, and thus discover the unity of his life, and the mystery of the providence that spared him so long?

If so, we will look, first and most naturally, at his sixty-year career in seminary and university; for there, without a shadow of doubt, his particular vocation lay. We will examine his teaching and lecturing, his published and unpublished writings, the recorded consultations and interviews and responses to questions, his studies of his beloved Thomas Aquinas and his own independent philosophy and theology, the method he created to push forward the boundaries of knowledge in these and other fields—the whole great accumulation of half a century of unremitting labor and productivity, the products of his mind, and not just of his mind, but of his mind and heart, works of beauty too and not just of arid argument.

Is this the place to find the clue we seek? Certainly it is an area we would gladly explore, those of us who are convinced of the importance of that productivity for Church and world. But maybe this is not the time, nor this the place, for that exploration. In any case are we quite sure that the meaning and unity of life is to be discovered there? Is it the works we produce externally, be they works of hand or voice, of mind or heart, is it these products that reveal the mind of God on the work given each one of us to do?

At least, they do not seem to tell the whole story. Too often the great lord of life and death cuts short work half done or only started. Sometimes we are listening to a symphony on the radio, and a glorious piece of music is moving to achieve its incomparable unity, when a hand reaches out to switch off the radio, and the music comes to a sudden end, broken off in mid course. Does not God sometimes seem to act that way with us?

Bernard Lonergan was spared so shattering an interruption of his work. But even he had to round off one great book before it was really finished, complete another in shorter form, pressured by ill-health and an uncertain life-span, leave a third only partly ready at his death. And if we go back to the divine model himself, we find that his work too, considered as a product, was not so obviously completed: a few uncomprehending disciples, squabbling among themselves at the last supper itself, and running to escape at the first sign of danger—does this adequately describe the work that God gave the only Son to accomplish?

Maybe we have been somewhat hasty in determining what the prayer at the last supper means; maybe there is something more to be said.

Indeed there is another aspect to the task set the Son of God, and I find it in the Letter to the Hebrews: "It was clearly fitting that God for whom and through whom all things exist should, in bringing many sons to glory, make the leader who delivers them perfect through sufferings" (2:10). And, again, "Son though he was, he learned obedience in the school of suffering, and, once perfected, became the source of eternal salvation for all who obey him" (5:8-9).

Here surely is a new insight on the work that Jesus was given to do: not now the calling of disciples, not the teaching of a doctrine, not the founding of a church; rather, a work that directly concerned himself. He was to learn obedience, he was to perfect himself, he was to make of himself what God would have him be. To be sure, it was in and through achievement of the work which is a product, that he was to perfect himself, and make of himself what he was to be—through his calling of the disciples and the founding of a church—but in the order that Hebrews reveals, first to perfect himself and then to bring many children to glory.

And now maybe we can see a little more clearly, and in relation to the life of our lord and only master, what the work was which Bernard Lonergan was given to do, and how the years of his life form a unity. I would like, in order to make this clearer still, to use here a pair of ideas from his own writings. I know that some of you loved Bernard without always understanding what he wrote. But, just because you loved him, I know also you would like to hear how he would explain what I have been trying to say. He would use a pair of Greek words, *poiësis* and *praxis*. *Poiësis* refers to the work we produce, the product. When a carpenter builds a house, or a musician composes a sonata, or an author writes a book—all that refers to *poiësis*. But *praxis* lies behind all such production; it refers to our own conduct: our own deliberations and choices and decisions, our own responsible actions. There is a unity in the two: a carpenter does not build a house without making a deliberate choice, and we have no responsible action unless we do something. But it is *praxis* that makes us what we are, in what Bernard would call our existential decision: the decision of what we are to make of our lives, that is, what we are to make of ourselves. And, as what we make of ourselves is more important than any house we build, or music we compose, so in the very Son of God, as Hebrews says, it was of first importance that, Son though he was, he should learn obedience. From that the *poiësis* would follow: the doctrine, the disciples, the Church.

It is here too that we must look for the pattern of Fr. Bernard's life. More and more, as I discover in never-ending study of his writings, as I reflect on his manner of life, especially in these recent years, more and more, it seems to me, it was this realization that guided him as he

moved from the noontide of life to its evening. I think of a line that in its simple profundity speaks volumes to me, as I think it will to you. Writing of the good choices and actions that make us what we are, he calls them “the work of the free and responsible agent producing the first and only edition of himself.”³

The “first and only edition of himself”—that is a book I and each one of us must write alone as we go through life, producing day by day a new paragraph, to achieve the first and only edition of myself. The empire of an Alexander, the plays of a Shakespeare, the music of a Beethoven—all testify to the great potential of the human race. But God could raise up from the stones of this church those who would provide the empire or the plays or the music that God’s people need, or indeed the great works of Bernard Lonergan. There is only one person who can toil throughout life, who must toil throughout life, under God’s grace, of course, to accomplish the work given me at birth to do, and, turning it over to God at the end, say, with my lord and master, “It is finished.”

This is the work that Bernard Lonergan was about all his life, whether coursing down the rapids of the Lièvre with brothers Greg and Mark, or lecturing in Latin to six hundred and fifty students in the Gregorian University, or listening indulgently to the papers of his disciples at a Boston College Workshop, or—not least—accepting and enduring these last two years the gradual fading of his mental powers.

The one and only work that really mattered was the work of which he wrote last Monday morning the final paragraph, and turned it over to his maker for censorship and—we have not the slightest doubt—for divine approval.

3. *A Second Collection: Papers by Bernard J. F. Lonergan, S.J.*, p. 83.

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